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ELA Exemplar

January 2025

Name:

Class of:

Teacher:

Homerroom:

Reading Comprehension Passage A: *The Great Silence*

Part 1

Directions (1–24): Closely read each of the three passages below. After each passage, there are several multiple-choice questions. Select the best suggested answer to each question and record your answer on the separate answer sheet provided for you. You may use the margins to take notes as you read.

Reading Comprehension Passage A

The Great Silence

In this work of fiction, the narrator is a parrot who reveals its view of human attempts to communicate with intelligent species in outer space.

The humans use Arecibo¹ to look for extraterrestrial intelligence. Their desire to make a connection is so strong that they've created an ear capable of hearing across the universe.

But I and my fellow parrots are right here. Why aren't they interested in listening to our voices?

We're a nonhuman species capable of communicating with them. Aren't we exactly what humans are looking for?

The universe is so vast that intelligent life must surely have arisen many times. The universe is also so old that even one technological species would have had time to expand and fill the galaxy. Yet there is no sign of life anywhere except on Earth. Humans call this the Fermi Paradox.

One proposed solution to the Fermi Paradox is that intelligent species actively try to conceal their presence, to avoid being targeted by hostile invaders.

Speaking as a member of a species that has been driven nearly to extinction by humans, I can attest that this is a wise strategy.

It makes sense to remain quiet and avoid attracting attention.

The Fermi Paradox is sometimes known as the Great Silence. The universe ought to be a cacophony² of voices, but instead it is disconcertingly quiet.

Some humans theorize that intelligent species go extinct before they can expand into outer space. If they're correct, then the hush of the night sky is the **silence of a graveyard**.

Hundreds of years ago, my kind was so plentiful that the Rio Abajo Forest [Puerto Rico] resounded with our voices. Now we're almost gone. Soon this rain forest may be as silent as the rest of the universe.

There was an African gray parrot named Alex. He was famous for his cognitive abilities. Famous among humans, that is.

A human researcher named Irene Pepperberg spent thirty years studying Alex. She found that not only did Alex know the words for shapes and colors, he actually understood the concepts of shape and color.

Many scientists were skeptical that a bird could grasp abstract concepts. Humans like to think they're unique. But eventually Pepperberg convinced them that Alex wasn't just repeating words, that he understood what he was saying.

¹Arecibo — a former space observatory located in Arecibo, Puerto Rico

²cacophony — a jarring mixture of noises

Out of all my cousins, Alex was the one who came closest to being taken seriously as a communication partner by humans.

Alex died suddenly, when he was still relatively young. The evening before he died, Alex said to Pepperberg, “*You be good. I love you.*”

If humans are looking for a connection with a nonhuman intelligence, what more can they ask for than that?

Every parrot has a unique call that it uses to identify itself; biologists refer to this as the parrot’s “contact call.”

In 1974, astronomers used Arecibo to broadcast a message into outer space intended to demonstrate human intelligence. That was humanity’s contact call.

In the wild, parrots address each other by name. One bird **imitates another’s contact call** to get the other bird’s attention.

If humans ever detect the Arecibo message being sent back to Earth, they will know someone is trying to get their attention.

Parrots are vocal learners: we can learn to make new sounds after we’ve heard them. It’s an ability that few animals possess. A dog may understand dozens of commands, but it will never do anything but bark.

Humans are vocal learners, too. We have that in common. So humans and parrots share a special relationship with sound. We don’t simply cry out. We pronounce. We enunciate.

Perhaps that’s why humans built Arecibo the way they did. A receiver doesn’t have to be a transmitter, but Arecibo is both. It’s an ear for listening, and a mouth for speaking.

Humans have lived alongside parrots for thousands of years, and only recently have they considered the possibility that we might be intelligent.

I suppose I can’t blame them. We parrots used to think humans weren’t very bright. It’s hard to make sense of behavior that’s so different from your own.

But **parrots are more similar to humans than any extraterrestrial species will be**, and humans can observe us up close; they can look us in the eye...

It’s no coincidence that “aspiration” means both hope and the act of breathing.

When we speak, we use breath in our lungs to give our thoughts a physical form. The sounds we make are simultaneously our intentions and our life force.

I speak, therefore I am. Vocal learners, like parrots and humans, are perhaps the only ones who fully comprehend the truth of this.

There’s a pleasure that comes with shaping sounds with your mouth. It’s so **primal** and visceral that, throughout their history, humans have considered the activity a pathway to the divine.

Pythagorean mystics believed that vowels represented the music of the spheres, and chanted to draw power from them.

Pentecostal Christians believe that when they speak in tongues, they’re speaking the language used by angels in heaven.

Brahman Hindus believe that by reciting mantras, they are strengthening the building blocks of reality.

Only a species of vocal learners would ascribe³ such importance to sound in their mythologies. We parrots can appreciate that.

According to Hindu mythology, the universe was created with a sound: “om.” It is a syllable that contains within it everything that ever was and everything that will be.

When the Arecibo telescope is pointed at the space between stars, it hears a faint hum.

Astronomers call that the cosmic microwave background. It’s the **residual radiation of the Big Bang**, the explosion that created the universe fourteen billion years ago.

That syllable was so **resonant** that the night sky will keep vibrating for as long as the universe exists.

But you can also think of it as a barely audible reverberation⁴ of that original “om.”

When Arecibo is not listening to anything else, it hears the voice of creation.

We Puerto Rican parrots have our own myths.

They’re simpler than human mythology, but I think humans would take pleasure from them.

Alas, our myths are being lost as my species dies out.

I doubt the humans will have deciphered our language before we’re gone.

So the extinction of my species doesn’t just mean the loss of a group of birds.

It’s also the disappearance of our language, our rituals, our traditions.

It’s the silencing of our voice.

Human activity has brought my kind to the brink of extinction, but I don’t blame them for it.

They didn’t do it maliciously. They just weren’t paying attention.

And humans create such beautiful myths; what imaginations they have.

Perhaps that’s why their aspirations are so immense.

Look at Arecibo. Any species who can build such a thing must have greatness within them.

My species probably won’t be here for much longer; it’s likely that we’ll die before our time and join the Great Silence.

But before we go, we are sending a message to humanity.

We just hope the telescope at Arecibo will enable them to hear it.

The message is this:

You be good. I love you.

—Ted Chiang
adapted from “The Great Silence”
Exhalation, 2019
Alfred A. Knopf

³ascribe — credit

⁴reverberation — echo

1. **The Fermi Paradox** (line 10) explains why
 - (1) the age of the universe cannot be determined
 - (2) the Arecibo experiment has not succeeded
 - (3) other galaxies are expanding into space
 - (4) some planets could support intelligent life
2. The figurative language in line 19 suggests that intelligent extraterrestrials
 - (1) prefer to interact with other species in space
 - (2) have no reason to converse with other species
 - (3) miss the opportunity to connect with humans
 - (4) relate to humans without need of language
3. Alex's death (lines 33–34) is expressed using which literary device?
 - (1) an anecdote
 - (2) a metaphor
 - (3) an allegory
 - (4) a simile
4. Lines 39–44 suggest that extraterrestrials may
 - (1) maintain contact only with non-human species
 - (2) prove to be more intelligent than humans
 - (3) prefer non-verbal modes of communication
 - (4) mimic communications coming from Earth
5. In line 64, the word “primal” most nearly means
 - (1) unique
 - (2) natural
 - (3) deceptive
 - (4) unknowable
6. Lines 67–76 serve to show the historical
 - (1) similarities among ancient and modern creation beliefs
 - (2) connection between vocalization and spiritual expression
 - (3) shared ways people celebrate important events
 - (4) role of vocal performances in preserving cultural traditions
7. As used in line 81, “resonant” most nearly means
 - (1) rich
 - (2) muffled
 - (3) startling
 - (4) harsh
8. According to the narrator, “the voice of creation” (line 83) is the result of
 - (1) “the music of the spheres” (line 67)
 - (2) “the language used by angels” (lines 69–70)
 - (3) “reciting mantras” (line 71)
 - (4) “the Big Bang” (line 79)
9. Which statement best represents a central idea of the text?
 - (1) “The universe is also so old that even one technological species would have had time to expand and fill the galaxy” (lines 7–9)
 - (2) “Hundreds of years ago, my kind was so plentiful that the Rio Abajo Forest [Puerto Rico] resounded with our voices” (lines 20–21)
 - (3) “But parrots are more similar to humans than any extraterrestrial species will be” (line 56)
 - (4) “Look at Arecibo. Any species who can build such a thing must have greatness within them” (lines 93–94)

Annotated Scoring Key & Evidence (Questions 1–9)

1. **Q1. Correct choice:** (2)

“The universe is so vast that intelligent life must surely have arisen many times. . . . Yet there is no sign of life anywhere except on Earth. Humans call this the Fermi Paradox” (lines 6–10).

Explanation: The boxed definition shows the paradox concerns why we have not succeeded in finding aliens even though conditions favour their existence, matching choice (2).

2. **Q2. Correct choice:** (3)

Line 19 describes the sky as “the silence of a graveyard,” implying **missed opportunity** to hear others.

Explanation: The graveyard metaphor suggests intelligent beings once could have spoken but no longer do, so humans miss the opportunity to connect (choice 3).

3. **Q3. Correct choice:** (1) an anecdote

“Alex died suddenly . . . The evening before he died, Alex said to Pepperberg, ‘You be good. I love you.’” (lines 33–34).

Explanation: The narrator recounts a brief, personal story about Alex; a single illustrative incident is an anecdote.

4. **Q4. Correct choice:** (4)

“One bird imitates another’s contact call to get the other bird’s attention.” (lines 41–44)

Explanation: The parrots copy calls they hear—literally mimicking communications coming from another source (Earth, in the parallel Arecibo example).

5. **Q5. Correct choice:** (2)

“There’s a pleasure that comes with shaping sounds with your mouth. It’s so primal . . .” (line 64)

Explanation: The sentence links “primal” to a basic, instinctive activity, closest in meaning to natural.

6. **Q6. Correct choice:** (2)

Lines 67–76 catalogue beliefs that sound or speech gives access to the divine: Pythagoreans, Pentecostals, Brahman Hindus.

Explanation: Each example ties vocalisation to spirituality, demonstrating the connection between vocalisation and spiritual expression.

7. **Q7. Correct choice:** (1)

“That syllable was so resonant that the night sky will keep vibrating . . .” (line 81)

Explanation: In context, “resonant” describes a powerful, full sound—closest to rich.

8. **Q8. Correct choice:** (4)

“Astronomers call that the cosmic microwave background. It’s the residual radiation of the Big Bang the explosion . . .” (lines 77–79)

Explanation: The narrator equates “voice of creation” with echoes of the Big Bang (choice 4).

9. **Q9. Correct choice:** (3)

“Parrots are more similar to humans than any extraterrestrial species will be, and humans can observe us up close ...” (line 56)

Explanation: The boxed thesis—that parrots, not aliens, offer humanity its best chance at inter-species understanding—captures the passage’s central idea better than the other options.